corruption. His focus now is two-fold: to combat corruption and project an image of unimpeachable integrity.

Soren has already delivered on a key electoral promise by increasing financial assistance under the Maiya Samman Yojana from Rs 1,000 to Rs 2,500. Launched in August, the scheme provides aid to women aged 18-50 and was credited with playing a pivotal role in the coalition's victory. However, the expanded outlay presents significant fiscal challenges. The scheme will cost the state exchequer Rs 16,000 crore annually. It's no surprise, then, that Soren has called for stringent financial discipline among his ministers while also exploring legal avenues to recover Rs 1.36 lakh crore in unpaid coal royalties and land compensation from the central government.

BUOYED BY A RESOUNDING ELECTORAL VICTORY, SOREN IS ACUTELY AWARE OF THE WEIGHT OF PUBLIC TRUST

The 17-point advisory, issued at the second cabinet meeting post-portfolio allocation, is unprecedented in Jharkhand's legislative history. It urges ministers to evaluate the viability of proposals before presenting them at cabinet meetings. The advisory mandates consultations with the departments of finance, law and personnel to forestall legal or fiscal hurdles. Soren has further directed his ministers to visit districts to assess departmental operations, identify gaps and gather feedback from beneficiaries of government schemes. There is a clear push to expedite long-delayed projects and extend government initiatives to remote and often neglected regions.

Revenue generation remains another critical focus. Ministers have been tasked with reviewing unused departmental assets and ensuring their optimal use, alongside beginning preparations for the 2025-26 fiscal year with clear targets. The directive also prioritises resolving pending employee promotions, addressing court cases and bolstering the government's legal standing.

Coalition management, however, remains a minefield. With seven ministers from the JMM, four from the Congress and one from the RJD, the delicate task of portfolio allocation has already sparked controversy. A leaked letter purportedly written by the Congress leadership hit the public space shortly after the swearing-in ceremony. It speaks about approving portfolios for the Congress ministers, raising questions about Soren's authority. While the JMM, with 34 MLAs, is the largest party, Soren relies on the Congress's 16 MLAs for a simple majority, leaving room for potential pressure from the party's high command in Delhi.

Meanwhile, Soren has reinstated Anurag Gupta as the state's director general of police, a controversial move given Gupta's removal by the Election Commission. Nonetheless, he has instructed the police to intensify their crackdown on crime, particularly cybercrime and organised criminal activities.

For now, CM Soren seems to have set the tone for decisive governance, steering through the intricate dynamics of politics with an eye on the state's future. ■



Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

By Rohit Parihar

Two Vaishnavite sects claiming ownership over a venerated temple and *math* (monastery), a beleaguered *mahant* (head priest), decades-long litigation and charges of mismanagement of temple property—Rajasthan's famous Galta Peeth temple is caught in a vicious temporal tangle. Just 12 km from Jaipur and nestled in the lap of the lush Aravalis, the complex of institutions known as Galta Peeth evolved as a revered Vaishnav centre by the 15th-16th centuries. The *peeth* has traditionally been controlled by the Ramanuja sect of Vaishnavism. The roots of the controversy go back to 1943 when Ramodaracharya was appointed *mahant* by the Jaipur state. After registering the *peeth*—as the law demanded—under the then-new Rajasthan Public Charitable Trust Act in 1963, he also made an allowance for the *mahant*'s post being a hereditary one—an act many deem to be against temple rules. Ramodaracharya further changed the trust rules in 1999 and made it family-managed, ensuring his descendants would have control over the temple property. After his death in 2006, his son, Avdheshacharya was anointed *mahant*. This was contested in court and demands made for the government to take control over Galta.